THE BIG PICTURE
CM Stalin and his officers at a dashboard review meeting



MECHANICS BEHIND THE DASHBOARD

The digital dashboard is a visual display of important information on government programmes, consolidated and arranged on a single screen for easy monitoring. For this, at the apex CM's office level, the Tamil Nadu e-Governance Agency (TNeGA) created the exclusive TN Decision Support System (DeTN) in October 2021. When needed, new features are added to provide functional utility and visual and analytical depth. DeTN, as a connected data ecosystem, is distinct from similar initiatives in other states as it runs from the CMO. This is even as government departments, directorates and flagship projects are in different stages of developing software on their own to assist the initiative.

220 directorates will have dashboards in their offices by March-end. Currently, the CM's dashboard provides real-time information on storage levels of key reservoirs, rainfall patterns, the price mesh that monitors the price stability of over 25 foodgrains, vegetables and fruits, current employment trends, civil supplies' stocks status, health-related information, daily police reports of major crimes with reference to districts that require attention, housing progress for the urban and rural poor and progress of water supply schemes. The public grievance redressal system and the status of petitions received through the CM's Helpline and 'CM in your Constituency' programmes are also tracked continuously. The last is of course to stay up to date on the slew of schemes launched by the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) government in line with its 500-odd pre-poll promises.

Stalin spends about two hours on an average to apprise himself of the status of projects that come up on his dashboard. It allows him to monitor both the macro and micro level situations in a viewer-friendly display. "The data is sourced in a manner that ensures integrity, to the extent possible, so that the CM gets to see progress, delays and correlation between the facts presented and analyses. This, in turn, helps drive evidence-based decision-making," explains P.W.C. Davidar, a retired civil servant who is advisor (digital and simplified governance) to the Tamil Nadu e-Governance Agency (TNeGA) that steers the Tamil Nadu Decision Support System (see box *Mechanics Behind the Dashboard*).

Among the dashboards, the ones relating to the state police are often the most viewed and analysed. They give Stalin updates on law and order, crimes, crackdown on narcotics and even district-wise variance in certain crimes. This has already helped in addressing two serious situations—the discovery that lethal arms in the hands of the police far exceed known numbers of non-lethal ones and putting a finger on the high crime incidence in textiles hub Tiruppur. In the first case, the CM has called for more intense planning to curb the number of lethal weapons and increased resources for personnel to have lathis and other non-lethal arms to tackle any situation.

As for Tiruppur, the data analysis revealed that while the resident population is about 500,000, the actual numbers, including migrants—mostly textile industry workers—is around 1.4 million. However, there were only 13 police stations (Tirunelveli, with a much smaller population, has as many). Immediate action was taken to increase the number of police stations and beef up staff strength in Tiruppur. The dashboard numbers have also helped monitor the performance of the superintendents of police (SPs) in the districts as well as track crime prevention measures and understand prevalence of crimes in specific regions.

Another domain that is tracked closely is the revenue department, which processes 27 essential citizen-centric certificates, apart from land transfer documents. Clearance pendency is always a concern and Stalin's watch has helped speed things up. The application disposal time is also tracked now to see if it has improved since the previous All India Anna Dravida Munnetram Kazhagam (AIADMK) government, an added bonus since politicians are always looking to score brownie points. The data assessment also found that there are 800-odd vacancies of land surveyors, which was also leading to delays. The CM has now asked that recruitments for the posts, done via the State Public Service Commission, be completed by mid-2023.

Dashboards, except in the case of public transport, do not cover financial review of the departments and undertakings. That task is handled by the state finance department. The transport department dashboards